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CS368
20 March 2026

Microtransaction's Effect on Adolescents

Microtransactions in video games allow players to purchase in-game currency using real money. They are most prevalent in free-to-play games, where companies monetize their products while keeping the game free to access. Many of the most successful free-to-play games of the past decade such as Fortnite and Roblox generate billions of dollars annually through in-game purchases and promoting enticing in-game cosmetics. Even full-priced titles like Call of Duty and NBA2K include additional monetization systems at launch. Although these purchases are often framed as optional or cosmetic, their design and marketing strategies negatively affect young players.

Microtransaction-based game economies are harmful and predatory towards minors because they exploit young vulnerable minds by using psychologically manipulative design practices, and normalizing gambling-like spending behaviors.

Children and adolescents are particularly vulnerable to these monetization systems due to impressionable and cognitive factors. Research suggests that opening loot boxes is associated with early gambling behaviors, especially in adolescents, who are particularly susceptible to problem gambling (Zendle, 2019). Because impulse control and decision making skills are still developing during adolescence, minors are more susceptible to reward-based systems that inject immediate dopamine to the brain. Additionally, many young gamers lack financial literacy and may not fully understand how quickly small in-game purchases can accumulate over time will have real-world spending consequences. The combination of children's immaturity and exposure to a gambling-like mechanics create an environment in which minors are more likely to overspend.

Game developers deliberately implement psychological tactics that encourage spending. Loot boxes, for example, rely on randomized reward systems that essentially resemble slot machines. Players may earn these loot boxes through gameplay or purchase them instantly for real money. These developers prey on people's impatience, hoping they will fork over real money in order to save time and unlock rare in-game rewards. Many hardcore gamers might remember the Star Wars Battlefront II loot crate controversy that sparked outrage with their pay-to-win and gambling mechanics. The public backlash eventually led to lawsuits against video game publishers like EA, alleging that companies knowingly design games to exploit young people's addiction

habits (TorHoerman Law, n.d). Video game companies intentionally and carefully implement systems to exploit young players and encourage excessive spending.

Cosmetic microtransactions like V-bucks and Robux, which do not directly affect gameplay performance, can exert social pressure on young players. In games like Fortnite, cosmetic skins, emotes, and especially limit-time collaborations are marketed as exclusivity, and symbols of status. These items often rotate in short availability windows, creating fear of missing out. For minors, owning these rare, shiny items is closely tied to peer perception and belonging. The FTC's settlement regarding deceptive practices in Fortnite illustrates how easily minors can make unauthorized charges while attempting to purchase items (Time, 2023). Although cosmetics may seem harmless, they are strategically designed to exploit children's desire for social acceptance, increasing the likelihood of impulsive spending.

The effects of microtransactions have shifted video games away from being harmless entertainment to profit-driven schemes that exploit young minds. When developers knowingly develop games around tactics that take advantage of young player's impulsiveness, they prioritize profit over well-being. Because adolescents are easily vulnerable to impulse-drive and reward-based systems, targeting them with monetization strategies should be recognized as ethically predatory and treated with scrutiny.

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